Double D

By Jim Dalglish

Lights up. N&N Women's Shoes, an ancient, rather rundown shoe store on a neglected side street of Manhattan. The shoes displayed are top-notch, but the stores fixtures look like they had their heyday in the early 70s. Nigel, a slightly effeminate man who looks like his heyday was also in the early 70s, can be seen standing behind the cash register, reading a men's fashion magazine - He is tall and his hair is receding. He is humming "These Boots Were Made for Walking." He glances at his watch and notices that it's time to close. He then grabs a box of shoes from the floor and exits offstage right. He moves briskly with a bit of bounce in his step. Mary enters the shop. She is a big girl - big bones, big hair, big breasts, big ... everything. She is wearing a very fashionable, stylish dress. It looks like hell on her. She walks cautiously, like her feet hurt. As Mary enters, the lights go out - as though Nigel has turned out the lights from the back room.

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS: Tolerance is the capacity to accept and understand people who are different from you. As you become tolerant of others, you will be better able to learn from and work with a wide variety of people. This is a crucial strength of mature people, and it is essential in a healthy community.

ACTOR: At one time or another, most of us have been stereotyped -- labeled by others as dumb jocks, weird computer geeks, or flaky theater folk, for example. These stereotyped views can lead to intolerance. Many people of color or members of different religions frequently feel the cold shoulder and distant stares of intolerance from others.

ACTRESS: When this happens to you, you have a few options. You can turn the negativity inward and feel bad about yourself. You can turn it outward and be angry and bitter. Or you can try to grow.

ACTOR: In Double D by Jim Dalglish Mary and Nigel, discover the peace that can be discover through just such growth.

TOGETHER: Double D by Jim Dalglish

MARY: Hello? *(Nigel re-enters. He sees Mary and stops.)*

NIGEL: Oh, boy.

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MARY: Are you closed?

NIGEL: Uh-huh. *(Mary begins to lose her composure.)*

MARY: Oh ... uh ... Really?

NIGEL: Uh-huh.

MARY: Yes ... well ... I'm ... Oh ... *(Mary begins to exit. Her feet are killing her and she's on the verge of tears)*

NIGEL: Wait a minute. *(Mary turns expectantly)* Is that a Galliano?

MARY: What?

NIGEL: Your dress. Is it a knockoff or did I see Naomi Campbell wear it in Bryant Park last fall?

MARY: My mother picked it out.

NIGEL: Expensive taste.

MARY: If you knew how many fittings I had to endure.

NIGEL: What's a girl like you doing in Dior? *(Mary is thrown by the comment. She begins to cry hysterically)*

NIGEL: What? . . . *(Realizing:)* Oh . . . I guess that wasn't . . . I shouldn't have ... Oh, boy.

MARY: You're right. I look like a knocked-up sow in a silk parry dress. .. Like a whole hog stuffed into in a pink satin sausage.

NIGEL: ... no ...

MARY: That's what she my mother said.

NIGEL: Then she's going blind. Because what I see before me is ...

MARY: What?

NIGEL: A very lovely woman.

MARY: I'll get out of here so you can close.

NIGEL: Wait. Can't go out like that. *(He hands her a tissue. She uses it to dab her eyes.)* Take a load off your ... *(Regretting his word choice.)* Sit down. Go ahead.

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I've got nowhere to go. Believe me. That's why I'm open so late. Nowhere to go.

MARY: Thanks, *(She sits)* Nice shop. *(Nigel looks around and smiles sadly at the irony.)* Not many open this late. Believe me. I've checked.

NIGEL: Shoe emergency? *(Mary plops her feet up on the Ledge in front of her chair. Her feet are enormous. This is the first time Nigel has seen her feet.)* Jesus Christ!

MARY: That's what they all say.

NIGEL: What size are they?

MARY: 12 Double D ... if I'm not retaining water and I elevate my feet for an hour before I go out ...

NIGEL: Oh, boy.

MARY: My shoes are so tight they're killing me. This strap ... It's like a knife. I swear I'd be bleeding to death, if these damn things didn't completely cut off my circulation.

NIGEL: How did you manage to get them on?

MARY: My mother ... I don't even know why I call her that. She's not my mother really. She's married to my father. She did this to me.

NIGEL: How?

MARY: A tub of ice for an hour.

NIGEL: Mother of God!

MARY: *There's no way you're going to my Crystal's engagement party wearing those Goddamned Birkenstocks!*

NIGEL: Not with that dress –

MARY: *(Renewed tears.)* Ohhhh ...

NIGEL: I'm sorry ... I ...

MARY: You don't know what it's like. You don't. To be trapped ... Completely trapped by your body. I want to be pretty. Just like my stepsister. The belle of the ball.

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Hell, I'm not greedy. I'll settle for just being presentable. Ahhhhhhh!!!!

NIGEL: *(Struggling to take off her shoe.)* The buckles are stuck.

MARY: Inside ... inside I'm beautiful, and smart, and glamorous. I feel all that. But then I look at myself in the mirror and ...

NIGEL: When does the party begin? *(Nigel continues to try pull the shoes off)*

MARY: I'm an hour late already. There wasn't any room for me in the limousine. But in the cab on the way to The Four Seasons, they started to throb so desperately I didn't think I could take it. I've been to every store in Midtown. One look at my feet and they all showed me the door. They're killing me. *(Nigel takes out a box cutter from his back pocket in his hand.)*

MARY: What are you going to do with that?

NIGEL: We'll have to cut them off.

MARY: She'll kill me!! *(Nigel cuts the straps with the box cutter. He delicately removes her feet from the shoes. At first Mary is relieved)*) .. . Oh ... Oh ...

NIGEL: You're free.

MARY: My feet ... the feeling is come back into my ... *(Screaming:)* Ahhhhhhhhh!! *(He begins to rub her feet.)*

NIGEL: Deep breaths ... Deep breaths ...

MARY: Ahhhhhhhhh!

NIGEL: Don't fight it. Accept the pain.

MARY: What have you done? Now what am I going to do? In twenty minutes I have to be standing in a reception line as the fat ugly stepsister of the most beautiful bride in the world.

MARY: *(Beginning to enjoy the foot rub.)* Oh ... oh ... oh ...

NIGEL: What's your name?

MARY: Mary.

NIGEL: I can help you, Mary.

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MARY: How? Have you studied the art of Japanese foot binding or something? **NIGEL:** *(Irish brogue:)* A little magic. *(Nigel disappears into the storage room.)* **MARY:** What?

NIGEL: I'll be right back. *(Nigel disappears into the storage room.)*

MARY: I'm usually not like this. I'm not. My father's wife ... I don't fit into her perfect picture of perfection. You know - thirty-five, morbidly obese, unmarried. If she could just see what I'm really like. In court during my final arguments. Or cross-examining a hostile witness. We don't get much of that in property law ... but I can be damn effective. *(Nigel reappears with boxes of shoes.)* And that daughter ... Can you be a size zero? Is that even possible?

NIGEL: The biggest sizes of the most fabulous shoes on Earth. *(He pulls the shoes out of their boxes and presents them to Mary one at a time. It is like a religious experience for him.)* Manolo Blahnik . . . Jimmy Choo . . . Ferragamo . . . Gucci . . . Pucci ... Givenchy ... Givenchy ... GIVENCHY!!

MARY: They're gorgeous! What sizes?

NIGEL: Mostly 10s and 11s ...

MARY: Won't work.

NIGEL: They're open-toed sandals.

MARY: No.

NIGEL: Come on ...

MARY: You don't know what I've been through .

NIGEL: Try. *(Nigel struggles to put the sandal on Mary's foot. It doesn't fit. He tries another. It doesn't fit. He tries another.)*

MARY: Oh, God ... oh God ...

NIGEL: It's not over yet. *(He tries a bunch more ... to no avail. One pair left. He picks it up reverently.)* The largest Ferragamo in the Western Hemisphere. *(He shoves it on her foot. She cries out. She looks down at her foot. It's hopeless.)*

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MARY: Like trying to stuff a hippo into a thimble.

NIGEL: It's the largest shoe in the shop.

MARY: What?!

NIGEL: ... The open toes and strap extenders ...

MARY: *(Picking up her sliced shoes.)* My shoes!

NIGEL: ... I thought it would work. But your feet!

MARY: They're ruined! What am I going to do? She'll kill me!

NIGEL: I'm sorry.

MARY: I have nothing. I can't even get home now. What am I going to do? *(She begins to cry again. He sprints into the back room.)* He'll forgive me, won't he? He's always said he loves me no matter how big I am. And I've been bigger ... If you can believe that. He still loves me. She hasn't ruined that too has she? Oh, Daddy ... *(Nigel re-enters, carrying a pile of old, dusty shoe boxes.)* What are those?

NIGEL: Shoes. *(He blows dust off the top of one of the boxes.)*

MARY: They're kind of dusty, aren't they?

NIGEL: They've been in storage for a few years.

MARY: Decades? *(She takes a shoe out of one of the boxes. It's a sequined pump.)* Good lord.

NIGEL: A classic.

MARY: They're huge and used.

NIGEL: Very gently, very respectfully.

MARY: Whose are they?

NIGEL: A friend of mine.

MARY: She stores her shoes here?

NIGEL: A very good friend.

MARY: Why doesn't she keep them in her closet?

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NIGEL: She left town ... suddenly ... about fifteen years ago. And hasn't come back since.

MARY: Is she OK?

NIGEL: A new part of her life ... afraid to look back. You get to be a certain age and your youth is just a little too hard to keep up.

MARY: It's very nice of you to keep them for her.

NIGEL: It makes me feel close to her.

MARY: That's sweet ... What's your name?

NIGEL: Nigel.

MARY: That's sweet, Nigel.

NIGEL: Shall we?

MARY: What size?

NIGEL: 14 C.

MARY: She must be very tall.

NIGEL: About my height ... in flats.

MARY: 14 C?

NIGEL: *(He removes a pair from a box. It's the exact shade as Mary's dress - or they can be made out of clear vinyl.)* Oh, Mary. My God, we have a perfect match!

MARY: *(Clapping.)* Oh! *(Suddenly concerned.)* But the heel!

NIGEL: What about it?

MARY: I can't. I've never worn a heel over an inch high.

NIGEL: What?!

MARY: I can't.

NIGEL: That's absurd! *(He slides the shoes onto Mary's feet.)*

MARY: Ahhhh ...

NIGEL: Eureka! *(She tries to stand. But is very wobbly.)*

NIGEL: Steady now ... *(She takes a few tentative steps.)*

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MARY: It's like I'm walking a tightrope. *(She takes a tumble.)* Oh ... Oh ...

NIGEL: Are you OK?

MARY: It's impossible!

NIGEL: Nonsense. You just need to practice.

MARY: Practice? I can't even get up. *(Nigel tries to help Mary stand. But she is very heavy.)* I live in constant fear that I'll fall and break my hip or I won't be able to get back up. That's the worst fear ... I won't be able to get back up ... *(Nigel summons some reserve of super-human strength and is able to hoist Mary up.)* Thank God ... thank God. And thank you, Nigel. *(She almost tumbles backward again. Nigel runs behind her and hoists her back onto her feet. Mary is very distraught.)* I can't ..

NIGEL: I don't want to hear it. You just need to find that woman inside. The woman you were telling me about. That powerful, confident woman who is so strong and brave ...

MARY: ... who wears Birkenstocks every day?

NIGEL: A big, beautiful powerful woman who doesn't take shit from anyone.

MARY: Right.

NIGEL: Shut up and listen to me, Mary. *(This leaves Mary dumbstruck.)* You can hide behind your little property law practice and your bad eating habits and your insecurities and self-pity until you grow old and lonely or die young. Or you can take this opportunity to finally be proud of who you are. Not the woman you see in the mirror with the big hair and bigger ass ... but the woman you are inside. The powerful, brilliant, creative, audacious, fun-loving woman who takes the world by the balls and gives them a little twist.

MARY: Excuse me?

NIGEL: A woman who doesn't let anyone tell her what to do, what to eat, what to wear. A woman who is sexy and glamorous ... who's got a lot to give and knows how to

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give it. Whose appetite for life is as big as her heart. I want to see that woman ... that big, bold, beautiful woman. High heels? Please! That woman could strap on snowshoes for an audience with the pope and be able to pull it off in high style. Give me that woman, Mary!

MARY: OK ... *(She takes a few tentative steps.)*

NIGEL: Let it go, girl! You got a stick up your ass. Let it all hang out! *(She moves more .freely.)* Give it to me. You own this room. Let me see you own it! *(She laughs and begins to strut a little)* That's it, honey. Make me feel it. Give me that power. Let me feel it. Give it to me! *(She really starts to get into it. She bobbles a little ...)* Just a speed bump. Nothing to worry about. *(As she struts up and down the store, Mary gradually transforms into a vivacious woman ...)*

NIGEL: Let me see you shake those va va's and wiggle that voom! Yeah, baby! Yeah! My bodacious baby!

MARY: (*Joyfully:}* My feet!

NIGEL: Feel the power? The thrill of three-inch spikes. There's a reason they're called spikes, Mary. Because they're weapons. Like two 45-caliber pistols strapped to each ankle. Power, Mary. Power. *(As she struts across the room in full stride. She's beautiful.)*

MARY: I can do it! I can do it! *(She laughs joyfully.)*

NIGEL: Piece of cake. *(She looks at her watch.)*

MARY: I'm late! What do I owe you?

NIGEL: What? Nothing.

MARY: But the shoes ...

NIGEL: She'll understand.

MARY: Could you thank her for me? You never told me her name ...

NIGEL: Nelly. Nelly Forbush.

MARY: That name sounds familiar.

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NIGEL: A musical star ... of sorts.

MARY: Really?

NIGEL: Mostly cabaret. A few select venues down on Greenwich.

MARY: I might have seen her perform.

NIGEL: Doubt it. Long time ago. Different life. Before she got old ... and tired.

MARY: I hope she's OK.

NIGEL: She's fine. She writes occasionally.

MARY: I have to give you something ... for the shoes.

NIGEL: Nelly's an old trooper. She'd understand.

MARY: She sounds like an amazing woman.

NIGEL: Nelly? She's a sassy old broad.

MARY: *(She smiles at Nigel with a twinkle in her eye.) (Directly to **NIGEL:**)* Thank you, Nelly. *(He blushes.)*

NIGEL: Come back tomorrow and tell me how it goes.

MARY: *(Suddenly nervous.)* Oh ...

NIGEL: You can do it. They're magic shoes. They'll get you through this.

MARY: I'm a powerful woman. I'm a powerful woman. I'm a powerful woman ... *(She repeats the mantra as she exits the shop.)*

NIGEL: You go, girl! *(After she leaves, Nigel crosses back into the room. He sees the red-sequined stiletto pumps. He holds them reverently. He removes his shoes and slowly puts them on. He revels in the act of buckling them on. He rises to his feet and poses.) (He crosses to center stage and turns his back to the audience) (He takes off his glasses. The song "J Will Survive" plays. He turns and lip-synchs the lyrics. He has a completely choreographed routine. He's amazing. This goes on for a while.)* Nelly, girl. You still got it! *(He stops in front of the mirror. He squints to see himself in the mirror. He puts his glasses back on. Then he sees his reflection in the mirror and freezes. He slowly loses his*

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posture, his poise, his presence. His shoulders droop and he looks awkward in the heels. He is back to being Nigel. He looks closer. And then he discovers Nigel again. He is surprised to discover that he likes what he sees after all.)

Hello there, Nigel. *(He smiles a beautiful smile.) (Lights fade.)*

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Jim Dalglish
Book: 2006: The Best Ten-Minute Plays for 2 Actors
ISBN: 978-1575255637
Publisher: Smith & Kraus
Date (Month/Year): Sept 2007

AWARD HISTORY

AZ State Finalist

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